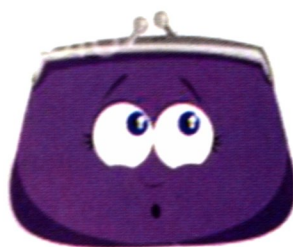
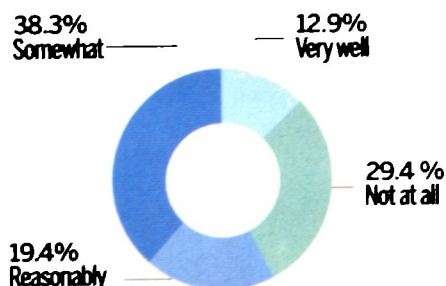




PAYING UP

Were you informed well about charges?



**Pocket
pincher**

54.2% patients on average found their hospital charges way too high

Most expensive

1. Wockhardt, Bangalore
2. Manipal Hospital, Bangalore
3. Sri Ramachandra Med Col, Chennai
4. Apollo Gleneagles, Kolkata
5. Care Banjara, Hyderabad and AMRI, Salt Lake, Kolkata

Least informative

1. Rockland Hospital, Delhi
2. Indraprastha Apollo, Delhi
3. Batra Hospital, Delhi
4. All India Institute of Medical Sciences, Delhi
5. Wockhardt Mulund, Mumbai

How long did you wait for the bill after discharge?

The average waiting time in superspecialties is about **33.3 minutes**

Lilavati Hospital, Mumbai, was the fastest **18.3 minutes**

Sir Gangaram Hospital, Delhi, was the slowest **48.6 minutes**

perspecialties. Most patients revealed that they had little clue about the sort of financial burden they were taking on; 29 per cent across all superspecialties were not informed at all and 54 per cent found hospital fees higher than market rates. Bali denies this as "an absolute myth". "Our pricing is extremely transparent," he asserts. "We follow a no-compromise approach. And the value that we offer far exceeds the money paid." Trehan adds a caveat: "Those who provide good service at affordable costs will be the ultimate winners."

Despite the roar and rumble, Indian hospitals seem to be on the right path. A resounding 95 per cent would recommend their hospital to a close friend or relative.

Care is the cornerstone of the patient-hospital relationship. But in a country where one thanks the stars on coming out of a hospital alive and well—and the chances of not doing so are one in 30 for many surgical procedures—isn't "patient satisfaction" a much-hyped concept? Prathap Reddy doesn't think so: "In their letters of appreciation, patients never

METHODOLOGY

The survey was conducted at 45 primary and secondary hospitals, 17 tertiary and superspecialties, covering 4,000 consumers from six metros and nine districts over 2007-08 and submitted to the Government in November 2008.

Quality of health has different meaning for providers and recipients of healthcare. For the former, it's clinical (affiliation, technology, mortality, discharge, treatment, surgical procedures etc). For patients, it's more subjective. This study was done purely from their perspective.

A Key Performance Indicators model was adopted. A Situation Appraisal Analysis was then conducted to identify factors that impact quality of service. Secondary studies and interaction with stake-holders suggested 110 factors and an Importance-Influence Matrix was drawn up to identify those—safety, security, services, food, cleanliness, availability of medicine, quietness, staff behaviour, communication, speed of service, waiting facilities, location, signage, fees, etc. The choice of hospitals was based on a tele-pilot survey of VOICE subscribers about facilities they frequented most in the last six months. Field workers had faced problems of accessibility in some (e.g. Jaslok, Asian Heart and Hinduja hospitals in Mumbai).

write about our doctors or all our high-tech equipment. They only talk about the nurses, the food and how cared for they felt." Caring lies not just in the treatment or doing it cheap, he holds, but when a patient goes back home satisfied and says, "My hospital did everything for me."

Which is why we brought you this survey. How a particular hospital fared here should not be taken as the final word. But it can surely be a good place to start the search for the level of care you or a loved one deserve when it is most needed. ■